SALES MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Sales Manager Essentials — Day 4: Coaching, Accountability, and Performance Improvement

Study guide · Self-study

Day 4: Coaching, Accountability, and Performance Improvement

How to Use This Guide

This guide is the learning material for Day 4. Work through it alone, at your own pace. Plan about 45 minutes.

Read each section, then do the exercises as you reach them. The "What Would You Say?" exercises ask you to write your answer before you look at the model answers at the end. Do that. The act of writing forces a real decision, and the gap between your answer and the model answer is where you learn the most.

The Upskill Challenge is not optional reading. It is your next practice on the job. It asks you to coach a real conversation with a real member of your team before Day 5. If you have not coached anyone yet, start this week.

The model answers are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you. The structure matters; the exact phrasing does not.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how to tell the difference between a skill gap, a process gap, a capacity problem and a misread expectation — and why each one needs a different corrective action.

Attitude: You will stop treating coaching as something you do when there is time, and start treating it as the core of your role.

Skill: You will be able to run an evidence-based coaching conversation using SBI feedback, agree a measurable commitment, and set a follow-up date.

Upskill: You will write a complete performance improvement plan for a team or a manager, with actions, owners, measures and review dates.

Diagnose Before You Coach

The most common coaching mistake is coaching the wrong thing. A person misses their number. You feel the urge to say "work harder" or "ask better questions." But the gap has a cause, and the cause decides the cure. Coach the wrong cause and you will spend energy fighting a symptom.

Separate four kinds of gap before you open your mouth.

A skill gap: the person does not yet know how to do it. Example: they have never learned to run a discovery conversation that surfaces the client's real deadline.

A process gap: the person can do it, but the system around them makes it hard. Example: leads arrive without key information, or approvals take days.

A capacity gap: the person has more work than time. Example: one rep carries double the accounts and cannot follow up on all of them.

An expectation gap: the person understood a different target or standard from the one you meant. Example: they thought "pipeline by Friday" meant leads in the system, and you meant qualified opportunities.

Each one has a different fix. Skill gaps need practice. Process gaps need a system change and someone who owns it. Capacity gaps need reallocation or a decision about what gets dropped. Expectation gaps need a clear reset of the standard.

> **NOTES**
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> When you feel the urge to correct someone, pause first. Ask yourself: can they do the task? If you are not sure, watch them do it before you decide.

The Psychology of Feedback

People do not change because they are told to. They change because they try something, get specific feedback, and try again.

Picture what happens in a rep's head when you say "you need to be more confident." The instruction sounds clear to you. To them it is a fog. Confident how? Louder? Faster? Are they supposed to pretend? Nobody knows what to do next, so nothing changes.

Now picture specific feedback. "In that call you answered the price question before the client finished asking it." The rep can see the behavior, imagine an alternative, and try it. The fog clears.

There is a second reason specificity matters. Vague praise and vague criticism both feel evaluative. They tell the person something about your judgment of them. Specific feedback about a moment tells them about the work. That protects the relationship and makes the message easier to hear.

Finally, ownership matters. When you tell a rep the answer, they remember your words for a day. When you ask "what did you notice?" and they find the gap themselves, they remember it for a month. The question does the work; your job is to ask it and then stay quiet long enough for the answer to arrive.

What works and what does not:

- Works: a specific moment. Does not work: "Great job."
- Works: an observable behavior. Does not work: "Be more confident."
- Works: the impact on the client or the number. Does not work: a judgment of the person.
- Works: one thing at a time. Does not work: ten things at once.

SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact)

SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact; Center for Creative Leadership) is a feedback model in three parts: describe the specific Situation, the observable Behavior and its Impact, then have the person practice. Specific, factual feedback is easier to hear and act on.

Take each part in turn.

Situation: name the moment so precisely that you both know exactly where to look. "In the 10 a.m. call with the client who asked about the renewal."

Behavior: describe what you saw and heard, not what you concluded. "You answered the price question before she finished asking it." Compare the judgment version: "You were nervous." You cannot change "nervous." You can change "answered before she finished."

Impact: say what happened as a result. "She went quiet and the call ended two minutes later." Impact connects the behavior to the outcome the person cares about.

Then practice. Ask: "What would you do differently?" Let them answer. Then have them say the new version out loud, even in a thirty-second role-play. This last step is the one most managers skip, and it is the step that makes the change stick.

The order matters. Impact before practice gives the rep a reason to rehearse. Practice before impact means you are drilling a behavior with no anchor.

> **NOTES**
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> Watch the difference between behavior and judgment in your own notes. If you hear a feeling word ("he seemed annoyed"), stop and write what you actually saw ("he looked at his phone and said 'just send the basics'").

The Coaching Loop

Coaching follows five steps, in order.

1. Observe the real work. Sit on the call, join the meeting, read the thread. Do not coach from hearsay.

2. Give SBI feedback on one behavior. One. Not three.

3. Ask what they noticed. Let them find the gap. This is where ownership transfers.

4. Practice it now. Rehearse the alternative in the room, in one or two minutes.

5. Follow up. Set a date to watch for the behavior again. Feedback without follow-up is just an opinion.

The follow-up is what separates coaching from a conversation. When you agree to watch on Thursday, the rep knows the behavior is real, not a comment that disappears.

Coach What Goes Well, Too

Most managers only coach mistakes. That leaves a rep guessing what to repeat. "Nice work" does not close the gap. A positive SBI does.

Practice example: "In yesterday's pricing call, when the client said the other vendor was cheaper, you asked what exactly was on their quote. She stopped pushing and stayed on the line. Keep asking that question."

The rep now knows the exact move that works. They will repeat it, and they will teach it to a colleague.

Riding Along Without Taking Over

When you observe live, small choices decide whether the session builds capability or dependency.

Say why you are there. "I'm here to see what works, so we can build on it." Not: "I'm here to check on you." The first lowers defenses. The second raises them.

Stay quiet unless the client relationship or the sale is genuinely at risk. If you take over, you teach the rep that you will rescue them. They stop preparing, because the safety net is there. Worse, the client learns to address you instead of them.

Note behaviors, not impressions. Write what the rep said and did, word for word where you can. Your notes are the raw material for SBI.

Debrief within the hour, in private, while the moment is fresh. Feedback a day later loses its grip.

Never coach in front of a client or the team. Embarrassment triggers defensiveness, and defensiveness blocks learning.

> **NOTES**
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> Carry one page and a pen. Write the Situation, the exact Behavior, and the Impact as you see them. Bring the page into the debrief; it signals that you were watching the work, not judging the person.

From Coaching to Accountability: Agreeing Measurable Commitments

A coaching conversation that ends with "try it next time" is a hope, not a commitment. Close the loop with something you can both measure.

Agree the what: one behavior, one measure, one date. "You will ask the delivery-date question on every call. I will listen to five calls by Friday and check that it appears in each."

Agree the owner: the rep owns the behavior. You own the observation and the follow-up.

Agree the follow-up date before the meeting ends. Put it in both calendars.

This is where accountability lives. You are not being harsh; you are making the commitment visible so nobody has to guess whether it happened. A clear measure is a gift to a rep who wants to do better.

Choose measures that fit the gap.

- For a skill gap: a behavior seen in observed conversations.
- For a process gap: the system change made and the date it took effect.
- For a capacity gap: a reallocation decision and its effective date.
- For an expectation gap: a written standard the rep can repeat back to you.

Persistent Underperformance: Fair and Documented

Coaching is the first move, not the last resort. When a rep has had real coaching, clear measures, reasonable time and still misses the standard, you owe them honesty and a fair process.

A professional underperformance conversation has four parts.

Describe the gap against the measure. Not character. "Over the past four weeks, the delivery-date question appeared in two of the twenty calls I reviewed. We agreed it would appear in every call."

Show the support given. "We practiced it twice, and I sent you the call recordings."

State what happens next, with dates. "We will review again in three weeks, against the same measure."

Give a clear consequence. "If the measure is not met, we will move to a formal process." Say it plainly. People deserve to know where they stand.

Document every step. Write the dates of coaching, the measures, the observations and the outcomes. Documentation is not a weapon; it is fairness. It protects the rep as much as you.

Report the situation honestly. If a rep is at risk, say so in your own reviews. Never dress up a struggling rep's numbers to make your team look healthy. The truth reaches the client eventually.

> **NOTES**
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> Never open an underperformance conversation the day you decide it. Write the facts first, then rehearse the first two sentences out loud. If those two sentences sound like accusations, rewrite them around the measure.

Apply It in Your Role

As a new or aspiring Sales Manager with a team: schedule observations now, before a problem appears. Pick one behavior from your team's standard sales practice, watch two reps this week, and give SBI feedback. Follow up on a date you set.

As a manager of managers: coach the manager on how they coach. Use the same loop: observe a coaching conversation, give SBI on one behavior, practice, follow up.

With your own manager: report coaching activity, not only results. Show which behaviors you are building and what the measures show. Ask your manager to observe you and coach you too.

In your pipeline work: when a rep misses a measure, run the diagnosis before the conversation. Skill, process, capacity or expectation? The answer changes everything you say next.

Across roles: in retail counter settings, coach the moment at the counter. In B2B account work, coach the discovery call. In long-cycle sales, coach the follow-up cadence. Same loop, different moment.

No sales manager role yet? Do the same task with a business you know well (a past employer or a chain you buy from), or with the practice examples in this guide.

What Would You Say?

Write your answer to each situation before you read the model answers.

1. On an observation call, a rep handles a client's price objection well but never asks about the client's deadline. Give SBI on the call, including one correction and one thing to repeat.

2. A rep you have coached twice on the same behavior still misses it after four weeks. Write the first two sentences of the underperformance conversation.

3. A manager reports that her team's numbers are fine but she never observes calls. She says: "I don't have time; the numbers speak for themselves." What do you say?

Key Takeaways

- Diagnose before you coach. Skill, process, capacity and expectation gaps each need a different fix.
- Telling is not coaching. Specific feedback plus practice is what changes behavior.
- SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact): name the moment, the observable behavior and its impact, then have the person practice.
- Ask what they noticed. Let them find the gap; ownership follows.
- Coach one behavior at a time, and coach what goes well, not only mistakes.
- Agree a measure and a follow-up date. Feedback without follow-up is just an opinion.
- When underperformance persists, be clear, fair and documented, with a stated consequence and a date.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Pick one option each.

1. A rep misses a weekly measure. You check and find the leads arrive without the client's contact details, so follow-up is slow. What kind of gap is this?

   A. Skill gap

   B. Process gap

   C. Capacity gap

   D. Expectation gap

2. Which sentence is SBI behavior, not a judgment?

   A. "You were not confident on that call."

   B. "You seemed distracted at the meeting."

   C. "You answered the price question before the client finished asking."

   D. "Your calls need more energy."

3. A manager gives feedback and the rep nods, agrees, and then does the same thing on the next call. What did the manager most likely skip?

   A. The practice step and a follow-up date

   B. The Situation

   C. The Impact

   D. The observation

4. After two rounds of coaching and a clear measure, a rep still misses the standard after four weeks. What is the most professional next step?

   A. Keep coaching quietly and hope it improves

   B. Adjust the report so the team still looks healthy

   C. Hold an underperformance conversation with facts, support given, dates and a stated consequence

   D. Move the rep to a different team without telling them why

5. During a live observation, the client turns to you and asks a question the rep should answer. What do you do?

   A. Answer it fully; it builds client confidence in you

   B. Let the rep answer; step in only if the sale is genuinely at risk

   C. Take over the rest of the call to save it

   D. Correct the rep in front of the client

Upskill Challenge

Complete on the job before Day 5.

- ☐ Write a performance improvement plan for a fictional team or manager. Use made-up names and numbers.
- ☐ Complete the plan fields below with actions, owners, measures and review dates.
- ☐ Run one real coaching conversation with a member of your team, using SBI on one behavior and the five-step loop.
- ☐ Agree one measure and one follow-up date, and put the date in both calendars.
- ☐ Review your plan against the four gap types. Label the gap in the plan.
- ☐ No team yet? Role-play a sales call with a friend, then give them SBI on one behavior and agree a follow-up date.

Team or manager: ____

Gap type (skill, process, capacity, expectation): ____

Behavior or outcome to improve, stated as a measure: ____

Action 1: ____

Owner: ____

Action 2: ____

Owner: ____

Support you will provide: ____

Review date 1: ____

Review date 2: ____

Consequence if the measure is not met: ____

> **NOTES**
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> Keep the plan to two actions. A plan with five actions usually has no owner for any of them. When you run the real conversation, start with one positive SBI before the correction; it tells the rep what to keep, not only what to fix.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the structure and the principle.

Exercise 1: A rep handles a price objection well but misses the deadline question.

Positive SBI first: "In the call with the client who said our price was high, you asked what their current provider's quote actually included, and they stopped pushing and stayed on the line. Keep doing that."

Corrective SBI: "Later in the same call, you moved to the next item without asking when they need it delivered. So we cannot yet promise a date, and that date is what they will decide on. What did you notice?"

Practice: "Ask it once more, right after you confirm what they want. Say it out loud the way you would on the next call."

Why it works: One specific praise tells the rep what to repeat. One specific correction gives a reason and a rehearsal. The rep leaves knowing exactly what to do next.

Exercise 2: A rep still misses the same behavior after four weeks.

"This is the delivery-date question, and over the past four weeks I heard it in two of the twenty calls we reviewed. We agreed it would appear in every call."

"We practiced it twice and I sent you the recordings. We will review again in three weeks against the same measure, and if it is not met we will move to a formal process."

Why it works: Measured, not personal. It states the gap against the agreed measure, shows the support already given, sets the next date and gives a clear consequence. Nothing in it is a surprise to the rep, because every part was said before.

Exercise 3: A manager says the numbers speak for themselves.

"The numbers are good, and that is real. My concern is what happens when they slip: without observations, we will not know whether it is skill or something in the process. What would need to change for you to observe two calls a week and bring one behavior to each?"

Why it works: You acknowledge the result, then shift the question to what the numbers cannot show. You end with an open what question, not a demand, so the manager owns the answer.

Quiz answers:

1. B. The rep could do the task; the system around them blocked it. Process gaps are fixed by changing the process, not the person.

2. C. It describes what was seen and heard, which can be changed. The others are judgments about the person.

3. A. Practice and follow-up are what make a behavior stick. Agreement without a measure and a date rarely changes anything.

4. C. Fair underperformance is clear, documented and dated, with the support already given stated openly. Hiding the problem or dressing up the numbers is dishonest.

5. B. Taking over teaches the rep that you will rescue them, and it moves the client's trust from them to you.

References

Center for Creative Leadership (CCL). SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact).